

Solicitation questions and answers

- 1) from [REDACTED]: USNCC is looking for partners institutions who can provide associates level degree plans that will also fit a built in certificate and the 15 hours of Navy transfer credits all in one degree plan, correct? Is the built in certificate mandatory or is an associates that fits the 15 Navy credits without the certificate acceptable?

Lastly, Upper Iowa University does have stand alone certificates in Supply Chain Management, Human Resource Management, and Emergency Disaster Management. These are roughly 15 hour certificate programs. Am I understanding the call for proposals correctly that USNCC is looking for standalone certificates as well?

ANSWER: USNCC is seeking partner institutions that can offer stackable credentials within associate degree programs, including pathways that incorporate the 15 hours of Navy transfer credit. Integrating a built-in certificate within the associate degree is strongly aligned with our model, as it supports incremental credential attainment.

In addition, many of these programs are also offered as standalone certificate opportunities. Providing both embedded and standalone certificate pathways is encouraged, as it enables students to achieve credentials more efficiently and supports our broader mission of lifelong learning.

- 2) From the phase I document, under General Capabilities, is this statement

TECHNOLOGY/DATA Does the institution attest that Executive Level POC listed on Page 1 has reviewed the technology requirements? (NB: should the institution be determined viable – a comprehensive plan will be part of the Performance Approach Evaluation)

What document is the “Page 1” reference referring to?

What does “NB” mean?

ANSWER: Note removed. Phase 1 Form updated.

- 3) The Performance Work Statement appears to require partner schools to offer associate degrees — a credential traditionally associated with community colleges. As the College of Professional Studies (CPS) functions primarily as a graduate and bachelor's completion institution, I wanted to confirm whether this is a core contractual requirement that would preclude our participation.

ANSWER: As outlined in the solicitation, participating institutions must be able to offer associate degrees. While this requirement is not limited to community colleges specifically, the ability to confer associate-level credentials is a core element of the contract and is necessary for participation.

4) For the Fields (programs) listed in Table 1 of CIAS – Academic Program Classification, what is the anticipated timeline for the “Future” programs, specifically:

- 1 - Leadership Communication
- 2 - AI Practitioner Certificate
- 3 – Data Visualization and Analytics Certificate
- 4 - Supply Chain Management
- 5 - Logistics

ANSWER: The programs listed as “Future” in Table 1 of the CIAS – Academic Program Classification are illustrative of potential areas of expansion rather than firm commitments with defined launch timelines. USNCC continuously evaluates program development based on workforce needs, partner capacity, and mission priorities.

Currently, USNCC already offers programs in Logistics and Artificial Intelligence, demonstrating existing capability and alignment with these fields. The additional areas—Leadership Communication, AI Practitioner Certificate, Data Visualization and Analytics Certificate, and Supply Chain Management—represent prospective offerings under consideration, with implementation timelines to be determined as requirements and resources are finalized.

5) Does the April 21st deadline apply to the Volume I, non-price proposal, only?

ANSWER: The entire proposal submission to include the Phase I form, Phase II form, Volumes I and II are due 4:00 PM, 15-May-2026.

6) Is there a Volume III? It is referred to on page 55 of the solicitation.

ANSWER: Any reference to Volume III is removed from the solicitation. There are only Volumes I and II.

7) Regarding the economic price adjustment clause (page 66), will the scope of the clause include adjustments made at the federal level?

ANSWER: Price adjustment will be handled on a case by case basis.

8) Will the offerors be given a range of low to high headcount or course seat projections? If not, will the offerors be expected to quote a contract maximum or just a cost per registration?

ANSWER: No. Cost per registration.

9) [REDACTED] would like to apply to partner with USNCC on this. What would be our next step? We received the email below from the [REDACTED]. We have Phase I and II forms completed and ready to send.

ANSWER: The entire proposal submission to include the Phase I form, Phase II form, Volumes I and II are due on 30-April-2026 at 4:00 PM.

10) Can the deadline be extended by two weeks to **Tuesday, May 5th** to allow additional time for proposers to submit their proposals?

ANSWER: Deadline has been extended to 30-APR-2026 at 4:00 PM.

11) There is a reference to the price proposal as **Volume III** on pages 55 and 65 of the guidelines. Is this a typo as it is also referred to as **Volume II** on pages 55 and 59 of the solicitation guidelines?

ANSWER: Any reference to Volume III is removed from the solicitation. There are only Volumes I and II.

12) Should the offeror complete **Section B: Supplies or Services & Prices or Costs** on page 3 of the guidelines? Is this the **Attachment I “Pricing Spreadsheet”** being referenced on page 67 of the guidelines?

ANSWER: A spreadsheet will be provided via Amendment 0002 to the solicitation and will be labeled Attachment IV.

13) There is a reference to solicitation pricing pages on page 56 of the guidelines where it states that they must be completed by the offeror and it may be a stand-alone Excel file attachment. Where can we find these pricing pages?

ANSWER: A spreadsheet will be provided via Amendment 0002 to the solicitation and will be labeled Attachment IV.

14) What is the acronym list referenced on page 58 of the guidelines?

ANSWER: Attachment V, USNCC CIAS Definitions, is provided via Amendment 0001 to the subject solicitation.

15) Can you explain what this means and what are the certification requirements being referenced: *“Unless completed in SAM, RFP Section, Representation, Certification and Other Statements of Vendors - completed by the offeror. This includes the certification requirements of FAR 52.212-3”*. This is stated on page 66 of the guidelines.

ANSWER: Institutions are required to be registered in SAM prior to award and required to respond to the questions in FAR Clause 52.212-3 prior to award.

- 16) We have relevant examples of past performance work that are similar to the scope of this solicitation, however, the work was not performed in the past five years. Can we still share this information in the Past Performance Information form to demonstrate our experience?

ANSWER: Yes. Past Performance will be evaluated in accordance with the solicitation.

- 17) Where is the “**Attachment I USNCC CIAS Checklist of the Database of Accreditation for Postsecondary Institutions**” referenced on page 61 of the guidelines? This was not included with the other attachments.

ANSWER: Attachment I is the Performance Work Statement (PWS). The reference to Attachment I stated in Question #28 above is changed to the Phase I Form, Institutional Characteristics. See question 4 of the Phase I attachment for self-certification.

- 18) On page 55 of the guidelines, there is a sentence that says, “**Each page of each copy of the non-price proposal should include the following legend: Source Selection Information- See FAR 2.101 and 3.104.**” Can you clarify what this means?

ANSWER: Each page included in the response requires Source Selection Information – See FAR 2.101 and 3.104. Any documents that do not include this shall not be evaluated.

- 19) The instructions on page 58 of the guidelines state that the “Non-Price Proposal” is limited to a maximum of 20 pages total, however, it also states that for the Academic Capabilities section, we are limited to 1 page per academic field. Are we only allowed to have no more than 2 academic fields as to not exceed the 20-page limit or are we allowed to provide more than 2 academic fields (for example, 3 academic fields so 3 pages)?

ANSWER: See Amendment 0002

- 20) Is the degree information form referenced on page 62 of the guidelines the **Phase 2** attachment? Is this to be completed and serve as the Academic Capabilities section of the Volume I Non-Price Proposal? Please clarify.

ANSWER: The solicitation is corrected to reference the Phase II USNCC Academic Program Classification form. This Form is part of Volume I submission. and page count limitation. See Amendment 0002.

- 21) **Minimum Technical Capability at Award:** Can you confirm the minimum required data-sharing capability at the time of award? Specifically, is secure SFTP/CSV exchange acceptable initially if the institution can transition to API-based automation within the required implementation timeline?

ANSWER: Yes, SFTP/CSV exchange is acceptable initially with the intention of transitioning to API.

22) Tier Classification Impact: If an institution is initially classified as Tier 2, does this affect award consideration, or only implementation timing and initial enrollment capacity?

ANSWER: ?

23) NAV 101–105 ACE Status: Can you confirm whether the current NAV 101–105 courses remain aligned with the versions previously reviewed by ACE, and whether USNCC plans to resubmit these courses for updated ACE recommendations?

ANSWER:

NAV 101–105 courses remain aligned with the versions previously reviewed by ACE, and USNCC does not plan to resubmit them at this time. Credit recommendations are understood to be valid for up to 10 years absent substantive changes; USNCC is working with ACE to resolve the 2024 expiration discrepancy. In the interim, partner institutions may proceed with evaluation using current course materials, and existing ACE guidance remains applicable where training aligns.

24) ACE Expiration and Institutional Evaluation: We understand that the prior ACE credit recommendations for NAV 101–105 expired in 2024. In the absence of current ACE recommendations, are partner institutions proceeding with internal course evaluation using current syllabi and materials for articulation purposes, or does USNCC plan to provide updated ACE-aligned guidance?

ANSWER:

NAV 101–105 courses remain aligned with the versions previously reviewed by ACE, and USNCC does not plan to resubmit them at this time. Credit recommendations are understood to be valid for up to 10 years absent substantive changes; USNCC is working with ACE to resolve the 2024 expiration discrepancy. In the interim, partner institutions may proceed with evaluation using current course materials, and existing ACE guidance remains applicable where training aligns.

25) State Availability Expectations: Does USNCC expect partner institutions to offer all proposed programs in all 50 states, or is partial state availability acceptable if clearly identified?

ANSWER:

USNCC seeks partners capable of supporting a geographically dispersed, globally available Naval student population. While broad availability is strongly preferred, institutions may propose programs with partial state availability if limitations are clearly identified.

26) 1. To confirm our understanding, what is due on April 21, 2026, is *Volume I - Non-Price Proposal, Phase I Institutional Characteristics* only, correct? As per RFP N0018926RB002 page 60 of 77:

The selection of offerors for award will be conducted in two Phases. Phase I will consist of evaluation of the **Institutional I** Characteristics. Offerors who are determined to be Acceptable upon review of the **Institutional** Characteristics shall move on to Phase II. Offerors who are not determined to be Acceptable in Phase I will be notified that their proposal is no longer eligible for award and will not be included in the Phase II evaluation. Phase II will consist of the evaluation of Performance Approach, Academic Capabilities, Past Performance, and price. Phase II will consist of the evaluation of Performance Approach, Academic Capabilities, Past Performance, and price. The non-price evaluation factors will be considered significantly more important than price. The non-

And page 74 of 77:

The selection of offerors for award will be conducted in two Phases. Phase I will consist of evaluation of the Institutional Characteristics. Offerors who are determined to be Acceptable upon review of the Instructional Characteristics shall move on to Phase II. Offerors who are not determined to be Acceptable in Phase I will be notified that their proposal is no longer eligible for award and will not be included in the Phase II evaluation. Phase II will consist of the evaluation of Performance Approach, Academic Capabilities, Past Performance, and price. The non-price will be considered significantly more than price. Within the non-price proposal, Performance Approach, Academic Capabilities, and Past Performance are equally weighted. The Government's best-value award decision will be based upon the factors evaluated in Phase II.

ANSWER: The entire proposal submission package is due on 30-April-2026 at 4:00 PM.
Page 74-77 - entire proposal package is due – Phase I along with Proposal submission with Phase II.

27) Is there anything else we should review / make sure to include in the contract application by the deadline of April 21, 2026? When are the due dates for the Volume I, Phase II and Volumes II-III?

ANSWER: The entire proposal submission including the Phase I form, Phase II form, Volumes I and II are due on 30-April-2026 at 4:00 PM.

28) Where can I find the “Attachment I, USNCC CIAS Checklist of the Database of Accreditation for Postsecondary Institutions” listed on page 61 of 77 of the guidelines, as the Attachment I listed on the webpage (pictured below) is another document, not the one named “USNCC CIAS Checklist of the Database of Accreditation for Postsecondary Institutions”?

■ Attachments/Links	
Links	
Link	Updated Date
N0018926R0594_Phase_2.pdf	Mar 20, 2026
N0018926R0594_Phase_1.pdf	Mar 20, 2026
N0018926R0594_Past_Performance_Information_Form.docx	Mar 20, 2026
N0018926R0594_Attachment_III.pdf	Mar 20, 2026
N0018926R0594_Attachment_II.pdf	Mar 20, 2026
N0018926R0594_Attachment_I.pdf	Mar 20, 2026
N0018926R0594_Addendum_IV.pdf	Mar 20, 2026
N0018926R0594_Addendum_III.pdf	Mar 20, 2026
N0018926R0594_Addendum_II.pdf	Mar 20, 2026
N0018926R0594_Addendum_I.pdf	Mar 20, 2026
N0018926R0594_N0018926RB002.pdf	Mar 20, 2026

ANSWER: Attachment I is the Performance Work Statement (PWS). The reference to Attachment I stated in Question #28 above is changed to the Phase I Form, Institutional Characteristics. See question 4 of the Phase I attachment for self-certification.

- 29) Where can I find the Attachment I-“Pricing Spreadsheet” listed on page 65 of 77? If there is not a specific Excel template we need to use, is there a budget format you prefer? Again, the Attachment I listed on the webpage (pictured above) is another document, not the one named “Pricing Spreadsheet”.

ANSWER: A spreadsheet will be provided via Amendment 0002 to the solicitation and will be labeled Attachment IV.

- 30) Sometimes the guidelines list the “Non-Price Proposal” as Volume I or Volume II, and sometimes “Price Proposal” as Volume II or Volume III. Which name is the correct one/should we be using?

ANSWER: Any reference to Volume III has been removed from the solicitation.

- 31) What is meant by “2. A completed and signed page 1 of the most current version of the solicitation and any amendments” as listed on page 66 of 77?

ANSWER: The signature block 30 on the solicitation and the signature block on page 1 of any amendment shall be signed.

32) please clarify whether the full proposal is due on April 21, or if only the Phase I Institutional Characteristics document is required at that time?

Specifically, we are trying to determine if we should submit just the Phase I materials, or the entire proposal package, including all contents of Volume I (both Phase I and Phase II sections—Performance Approach, Academic Capabilities, and Past Performance) along with Volume II (Price Proposal).

ANSWER: The entire proposal submission, Volumes I and II, are due on 30-April-2026 at 4:00 PM. The Phase I and Phase II forms are part of the Volume I submission.

33) I see a response date of 4/21 required. Do we need to divulge our interest by this date or are you requiring the Phase 1 document submission by this date?

ANSWER: The entire proposal submission, Volumes I and II, are due on 30-April-2026 at 4:00 PM. The Phase I and Phase II forms are part of the Volume I submission.

34) The Performance Work Statement appears to require partner schools to offer associate degrees — a credential traditionally associated with community colleges. As the College of Professional Studies (CPS) functions primarily as a graduate and bachelor's completion institution, I wanted to confirm whether this is a core contractual requirement that would preclude our participation.

ANSWER: As outlined in the solicitation, participating institutions must be able to offer associate degrees. While this requirement is not limited to community colleges specifically, the ability to confer associate-level credentials is a core element of the contract and is necessary for participation.

35) For submission method, is it a single PDF file for all or is one file per volume, per phase? Any naming conventions required?

ANSWER: One file per volume. Naming convention example: *SCHOOL NAME_N0018926RB002_Volume II_PRICED FILE*

36) For the required attachments (accreditation forms, past performance, etc.), are those to be filled out and submitted as-is or incorporated into the narrative.

ANSWER: The Phase I and Phase II forms to be completed by Offerors are part of Volume I and are included in the page limitation count in accordance with the solicitation instructions.

37) Are there a maximum number of programs allowed?

ANSWER: no

- 38) The solicitation says offerors shall submit proposals in two separate volumes, then describes Volume I as Non-Price and Volume II as Price, but in the same section it also says the non-price volume must exclude pricing that would reveal the total pricing detailed in “Volume III.” Can you clarify what volume III is and where it goes?

ANSWER: Any reference to Volume III is removed from the solicitation. The priced volume refers to Volume II.

- 39) The accreditation checklist is required, but the actual checklist attachment appears to be missing from the package you uploaded. On page 61, the solicitation says the offeror shall certify it is included in the Database of Accredited Postsecondary Institutions and Programs and shall complete “Attachment I, USNCC CIAS Checklist of the Database of Accreditation for Postsecondary Institutions.” But the uploaded “Attachment I” is the PWS, not an accreditation checklist.

ANSWER: Requires correction in the PWS. - this is on question 4 of the Phase I attachment

- 40) For the Past Performance on pg. 63 of the solicitation, is that only for prior contracts that we would have had with the Navy?

ANSWER: no

- 41) The page-limit rules do not clearly say whether required forms included inside Volume I count against the factor page limits.

The solicitation requires completion of the Phase I institutional characteristics form, degree information form for academic capabilities, and past performance form. But the instructions do not clearly state whether those required forms count inside the 20-page Volume I maximum and inside the sub-limits for each factor, or whether completed forms are treated as exempt exhibits.

ANSWER: Phase I and Phase II forms to be completed by Offerors are part of Volume I and will be included in the page limitation count.

- 42) If programs are selected, when does the Navy anticipate program instruction to begin.

ANSWER: Program start timelines will vary based on partner institution readiness and the evolving needs of the Naval services. USNCC will coordinate with selected partners to determine appropriate launch dates.

43) Any program that is submitted must be 100% online learning.

ANSWER: Yes, all courses must be available in online learning.

44) Do offerors need to sign the consortium agreement and have an articulation agreement in place before submitting the proposal?

ANSWER: No.

45) Is there any evaluation criteria we should follow when writing the performance approach narrative?

ANSWER: Restated from the solicitation instructions contained in Section L:

The offeror shall provide in detail, a forward-looking performance approach that will successfully accomplish the requirements of the solicitation and PWS. This shall include a discussion regarding the non-academic functional and ancillary services to include admission and enrollment, online course delivery, and student support for all awarded programs. The offeror's performance approach shall address how it aligns with the USNCC learning outcomes and needs of the services. In addition, the contractor shall provide a transition plan that discusses launching new programs and a transition plan. The transition plan discussion should address if the institution closes entirely or closes a program (teach out), USNCC discontinues a program, a student leaves the USNCC program, or a student leaves the Service, (Transitioning Consortium Student), and if the Contract is terminated (Continuity of Services).

The offeror should describe any risks associated with the solicitation, including the PWS and any risks associated with implementation of the offeror's performance approach; describe any techniques and actions to mitigate such risks; and explain whether the techniques and actions identified for risk mitigation have been successfully used by the offeror.

The offeror should provide any other information the offeror considers relevant to the solicitation.

46) The description for the Performance Approach narrative in the guidelines states that offerors must address how their performance approach will align with USNCC learning outcomes and needs of the services. What are the USNCC learning outcomes? Can you provide this information?

ANSWER: USNCC institutional learning outcomes can be found on the usncc.edu website "about" page.

47) When can we expect the pricing sheet to be posted to Sam.gov?

ANSWER: See Amendment 0002.

48) Reference the weekly data requirements. Could you clarify what the actual requirements each week will be and at what point will they be initiated.

ANSWER: Regarding weekly data requirements, Partner Institutions will be expected to provide regular data submissions that include, at a minimum, admissions/enrollment data, course registration information, and weekly performance metrics such as attendance. In addition, periodic advisory reports will be required to support program monitoring and continuous improvement efforts.

These reporting requirements are anticipated to begin upon program launch and will continue on a recurring weekly basis throughout the period of performance. Specific formatting, submission processes, and any templates will be provided during the onboarding and kickoff phase.

With respect to program start dates, these will be finalized following the award process and subsequent coordination with selected partners. Additional details regarding timelines will be communicated at that time to ensure adequate preparation and alignment.

49) In reviewing Attachment II: *Academic Program Classification*, I wanted to confirm the intent of the emergent degrees and certificates marked with “.”**

Specifically, when the document references “certificates,” to ensure my understanding is correct: when the term “certificate” is used, does it generally refer to an academic certificate (e.g., a six-course, 18-credit program), rather than an industry certification? Or is USNCC referring to industry-recognized / industry-certified credentials? Or does this vary by field?

ANSWER: To clarify, the term “certificate” as used in this document refers to an academic certificate, specifically an undergraduate certificate program (e.g., a structured academic program consisting of a defined set of credit-bearing courses). It does not refer to industry certifications or third-party credentialing.

That said, USNCC is open to learning more about any relevant industry certifications or micro-credentialing opportunities that may be associated with the academic program, as this information may provide helpful context.

50) Does this mean a limit of 18 separate degree programs?

ANSWER: Yes. See Amendment 0003.

51) Is an academic field a broad grouping like “Engineering Fundamentals” or individual degree options within Engineering Fundamentals...

For example, we currently offer General Engineering AS and General Engineering Technology AAS and they have embedded certificates.

We may also offer several programs under another distinct academic field i.e. Health, and each will have a certificate (or two).

ANSWER: Anything under the "Engineering" umbrella would count as an academic field. This would include all of their Engineering programs, but they could also argue for separating them depending on the focus. Meaning - if it's Nuclear, Electrical, General, etc.

52) The blank form itself is over 1 page in length (see attached).

ANSWER: See Amendment 0003 Page limitation instruction.

53) Tuition appears to be structured as a cost per credit—can you confirm that understanding?

ANSWER:

USNCC Consortium for Integrated Academic Solutions

Pricing Template Instruction Sheet

The pricing template lists what programs a Partnership Institution (PI) may implement under the CIAS award. All programs that are listed on the pricing template, such as Military Studies, are programs currently implemented with a PI and currently have students enrolled. All programs listed in *italics*, such as *FY27 (Additive/Advance Manufacturing)* are programs in the current pipeline with the USNCC. All programs that are listed in the form [Insert Program] – FY27 are lines where a PI may add a program from Attachment III – USNCC Academic Program Classification.

Each program that a PI is including in their official response should be represented on the Pricing Template. This requires the PI to place a value in 5 columns for each program:

1) Tuition – cost per credit hour

- 2) Instructional Materials – Average cost of materials for this program per year
- 3) Term Fees – Average cost of fees per term per year
- 4) Annual Fees – Average cost of fees that are charged per year
- 5) Graduation Fees – Average cost of graduation fees

These values need to be carried over to all follow-on CLINs, i.e. if a PI inputs values for Military Studies in the Base Year (CLIN 0001), then those values will need to be input on CLIN 0002 through the additional 6-month period, a total of 5 additional tabs. This will need to be completed for all programs that a PI includes in their response.

PIs also have the option to input values for Program Management and IT/Data Support.

54) For items such as instructional materials and graduation fees, should these be averaged across credits, or reflected differently?

ANSWER: See answer to question #53.

55) Regarding this statement:

(1)(i) Have and maintain for the duration of the contract a current CMMC status at the following CMMC level, or higher: ____

Contracting Officer insert: CMMC Level 1 (Self); CMMC Level 2 (Self); CMMC Level 2 (C3PAO); or CMMC Level 3 (DIBCAC) for all information systems used in performance of the contract, task order, or delivery order that process, store, or transmit FCI or CUI; and

Will the Navy specify the required CMMC level, or are we expected to self-identify the highest level we can support?

ANSWER:

CMMC Level 1 (Self)

56) I don't completely understand the formulas in the CLIN 0001 (Yr1) tab. Should all the values (tuition, instructional materials, term fees, annual fees, and graduation fees) be added together to provide a total sum (column M) of the cost for a particular course? If so, all of the values are not captured in the formula in column M.

ANSWER: See Attachment IX Pricing Guide Instructions.

57) There also seems to be an invalid reference error in columns F, G & H in the tabs for years 2 through 5. How should this be corrected?

ANSWER: See updated Attachment IX pricing sheet.

58) You stated in the Q & A that applicants can also put in values for program management and IT/Data Support. Should these values represent any project personnel salary, fringe benefits and/or indirect costs?

ANSWER: The Government is requesting fully burdened rates and will conduct a price analysis of those fully burdened rates. A cost realism analysis evaluating the individual cost elements, I.e., direct labor rates, indirect expense amounts and rates covering overhead, G&A, fringe, profit, etc. will not be conducted.

59) What do the figures for seats, students, and old seats represent in columns N, O, and P? Do we need to use these numbers in our calculations?

ANSWER: Removed. See updated Attachment IX pricing sheet.

60) What is the normalized cost in column K? What does this represent?

ANSWER: Removed. See updated Attachment IX pricing sheet.

61) Can we change the number for credits/course in column L if we now use semester hours versus credit hours?

ANSWER: Yes. This should be explained by the Offeror in its pricing volume narrative.

62) Are the Customer Name & Location and Customer Point of Contact sections of the past performance form referring to the federal or private entity that awarded a contract/grant to the offeror?

ANSWER: It's the name of the entity with whom the Offeror has contracted with in support of the specific contract reference.

63) Columbia College is interested in responding to the USNCC solicitation. Can you confirm that the response (due April 21, 2026) includes the following completed documents?

Response Form Phase I
Response Form Phase II

Are there any other forms or documents expected with the April 21st response?

ANSWER:

See proposal instructions. This includes submission both forms, Phases I and II. The closing date of the solicitation is extended to 4:00 PM EDT, 15-May-2026.

64) From the phase I document, under General Capabilities, is this statement

TECHNOLOGY/DATA Does the institution attest that Executive Level POC listed on Page 1 has reviewed the technology requirements? (NB: should the institution be determined viable – a comprehensive plan will be part of the Performance Approach Evaluation)

What document is the “Page 1” reference referring to? What does “NB” mean?

ANSWER:

Note removed. Updated Phase 1 Form is attached to the solicitation.

65) For the Solicitation Form, is there a guide to explain the content required for the boxes. Specifically, Block 12 says “Discount Items”. What are you looking for in this block?

ANSWER:

The primary "guide" for the SF 1449 is found within the **Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR)** and specific agency supplementals.

See www.acquisition.gov

On Standard Form (SF) 1449, *Solicitation/Contract/Order for Commercial Products and Commercial Services*, Block 12 is designated for Discount Terms.

This block is primarily used by the offeror (the contractor) to specify any discounts offered to the government for prompt payment.

Prompt Payment Discounts: If you offer a discount for early payment (e.g., "2% 10 days"), you enter those terms here. This indicates that if the government pays the invoice within 10 days, they can deduct 2% from the total.

- **Default Terms:** If you do not offer a specific discount, the industry standard is typically Net 30, which means the full amount is due within 30 days of receipt of a proper invoice.
- **Completing the Block:** Many agencies require this block to be filled out even if no discount is offered.
In such cases, you should write "Net 30" to indicate that no prompt payment discount applies.

66) Same Form, Block 17 requests CODE and FACILITY CODE. Is this the CAGE Code? What is the Facility Code?

ANSWER:

The "CODE" Box (CAGE Code)

The box labeled CODE is where you enter your Commercial and Government Entity (CAGE) Code.

- **What it is:** A five-character alphanumeric identifier assigned by the Defense Logistics Agency (DLA).
- **Why it's required:** It is the primary identifier used in DoD financial and procurement systems to link the contract to your legal entity and its registration in the System for Award Management (SAM).
- **Action:** If you have multiple CAGE codes for different divisions, ensure the one you enter here matches the Unique Entity ID (UEI) associated with the specific office performing the work.

The "FACILITY CODE" Box

The FACILITY CODE is less commonly used by commercial contractors but remains on the form for specific logistics and security purposes.

- **What it is:** This traditionally refers to a Facility Security Clearance (FSC) code or a specific shipping location code (like a DODAAC or a specialized plant code).
- **When to fill it in:**
 - **Leave it Blank:** For the vast majority of commercial products and services, this block should be left blank unless the specific solicitation instructions tell you otherwise.

67) Same Form, Blocks 23 and 24 are Unit Price and Amount. What are you looking for in these Blocks. Block 20 says, "See Schedule" What schedule?

ANSWER:

When Block 20 states "See Schedule," it means the description of what the government is buying is too long to fit into the small box on the first page. This is standard practice for Department of War (DoW) missions which often involve complex technical requirements.

The "Schedule" Defined

The "Schedule" refers to the subsequent pages of the solicitation or contract (usually starting on page 2 or 3) that contain the detailed Line Item breakdown.

In a standard federal solicitation, the schedule is typically Section B: Supplies or Services and Prices/Costs. It will list:

- CLINs (Contract Line Item Numbers): Specific items or services (e.g., 0001, 0002).
- Description: Detailed info on what each CLIN entails.
- Quantities/Units: How many and in what measurement (e.g., 12 Months, 500 Each).

Filling Out Blocks 23 and 24

These blocks are the financial "Bottom Line Up Front" for the entire contract.

Block	What the Government is Looking For
Block 23: Unit Price	The cost for one single unit of the item or service. <i>Example:</i> If you are providing 12 months of cloud support, the unit price is the cost per month.
Block 24: Amount	The Total Price for that specific line item (Quantity x Unit Price). <i>Example:</i> If you are providing 10 laptops at \$1,000 each, Block 24 would show \$10,000.

As stated in Amendment 0002, each awarded contract will contain a preestablished maximum ceiling of \$342M. Offerors will not complete blocks 23 and 24. See Attachment IX Pricing sheet to complete the required fields proposing credit hour rates and applicable fees, materials, Program Management, and IT/Data Support positions, if applicable.

- 68) Previously you stated the required response information is identified in pages 53 to 56. It references the Past Performance Form. I'm guessing this refers to past performances on contracts specifically with the US Navy and USNCC. If Columbia College has never been awarded a contract with USNCC, do I just write NONE on the form?

ANSWER:

Proposed contract references are not limited to prior or current contracts with the Department of Navy or USNCC. Offerors may propose any contract reference the institution considers similar in scope and relevant to the solicited requirement can be proposed irrespective of the

- 69) For this proposal, are the USNCC students to be considered military students using Military Tuition Assistance (MTA), or is the pricing calculated with the standard tuition rate? Our "military rate" is capped at the MTA of \$250 per credit hour and the annual cap for MTA is \$4000. How does this factor into this contract?

ANSWER:

Students are military. Tuition assistance is not a payment term for the solicited requirement.

Reference paragraph 3.15.5 of the Performance Work Statement, which states, "The Contractor shall ensure that the student is neither charged, nor is presented with a bill for tuition, at any time and in any form for USNCC funded courses during enrollment at the Contractor's institution. If the Contractor does not have mechanisms in place to suppress billing for USNCC students, such mechanisms shall be instituted within the first year of the contract award."

The Department of Defense's (DoD) Tuition Assistance (TA) program pursuant to the **Department of Defense Instruction 1322.25, "Voluntary Education Programs"** is **neither a term or condition referenced in the solicited requirement.**

- 70) On the Performance Work Statement (PWS), section 3.4.7.2 states "at least one pathway to a relevant bachelor degree program". Can you provide more information on "relevant"? Does a Bachelor of General Studies count, or does it have to be a degree tied to a specific discipline (e.g., Computer Science, Cybersecurity , Organizational Leadership)?

ANSWER:

The solicitation is clear on its face.

71) On the PWS, section 3.18.1.1, it states “The Contractor shall provide the Government with a list of all personnel assigned to this contract...” Can you define “assigned”? Over the life of the contract, there will be dozens of personnel associated with the contract, including faculty, advisors and coaches. Or are you looking for key personnel associated with functional areas, such as the CIO, Registrar, Director of Financial Aid, Director of Admissions, etc.?

ANSWER:

The Offeror shall provide a singular point of contact for all correspondence.

72) CIAS Attachment II (Academic Program Classification) identifies a list of associate degrees and certificates the USNCC has launched or may launch in the future, each identified with a specific Classification of Instructional Program (CIP) field. Do our associate degree and certificate submissions have to match up with the list you provided?

For example, [REDACTED] offers a sequence of certificate, associate degree and bachelor’s degree in Organization Leadership. This would seem to fit with your program with your AA in Organizational Leadership and Organizational Leadership certificate, which is listed for USNCC with the CIP Code of 28.

These are the Organizational Leadership programs we offer:

Organizational Leadership Certificate

Organizational Leadership Communication Certificate

Organizational Leadership: Fiscal and Analytical Certificate

A.S. Organizational Leadership

B.S. Organizational Leadership

We have these programs categorized under the CIP Code (Field) 52.0213. Since they are not in field 28, does that mean we cannot submit them for consideration?

ANSWER:

The solicitation is clear on its face.

73) The Solicitation Form, page 1, Blocks 15 and 20 say “See Schedule”. What Schedule is it referring to?

ANSWER:

See the answer provided under the question asking, “Same Form, Blocks 23 and 24 are Unit Price and Amount. What are you looking for in these Blocks. Block 20 says, “See Schedule” What schedule?”

74) From the phase I document, under General Capabilities, is this statement TECHNOLOGY/DATA Does the institution attest that Executive Level POC listed on Page 1 has reviewed the technology requirements? (NB: should the institution be determined viable – a comprehensive plan will be part of the Performance Approach Evaluation) What document is the “Page 1” reference referring to? What does “NB” mean?

ANSWER: Note removed. Phase 1 Form updated.

75) The [REDACTED] consists of “X” individual colleges across the Commonwealth who provide a wide array of programs based on economic demand in their service regions, among other factors. Their program pathways may consist of workforce (non-credit) credentials, Career Studies Certificates, Certificates, Diplomas, and both applied science and transfer degrees. Each institution is individually accredited and has varying levels of enrollment depending on their locations.

Questions:

- *Would you prefer one submission on behalf of the [REDACTED] to include up to the “X” colleges, or should each college submit their own proposal?*
- *In completing the Academic Capabilities Phase 2 form, colleges are finding they are exceeding the page limit when indicating the program pathways they would like to provide. If providing one submission on behalf of the system, we will indeed surpass the total page limitation; if we submit as a system, can that limitation be by institution (number of colleges submitting under the system’s proposal)?*
- *For past performance, would you prefer the past performance information for each individual college or one combined submission (note the page limitation here for individual responses)?*

- *Would you prefer one submission on behalf of the [REDACTED] to include up to the "X" colleges, or should each college submit their own proposal?*

ANSWER: It is up to the decision of the academic institution as to how it responds to the solicitation. The choice between a unified submission or individual college proposals should be based on the institution's internal governance, the specific requirements of the solicitation, and the strategy that best demonstrates the requested capabilities.

- *In completing the Academic Capabilities Phase 2 form, colleges are finding they are exceeding the page limit when indicating the program pathways they would like to provide. If providing one submission on behalf of the system, we will indeed surpass the total page limitation; if we submit as a system, can that limitation be by institution (number of colleges submitting under the system's proposal)?*

ANSWER: Should an Offeror submit a proposal as a System encompassing every school within the State or Commonwealth, the Offeror remains bound by the page limitations for each non-priced factor established in the solicitation, as updated in Amendment 0003.

- *For past performance, would you prefer the past performance information for each individual college or one combined submission (note the page limitation here for individual responses)?*

ANSWER: See above.

- 76) The Pricing Sheet has a column labeled Program. For this solicitation, programs are associate degrees and certificates, correct? If the certificate is embedded in the associate degree, the certificate is completed inherently with the completion of the associate degree...so there is no cost. Does this mean only stand-alone certificates are listed on the Pricing Sheet?

ANSWER: The program is for associate degrees and certificates. Offerors are to price the five columns in accordance with the pricing guide

- 1) Tuition – cost per credit hour
- 2) Instructional Materials – Average cost of materials for this program per year
- 3) Term Fees – Average cost of fees per term per year
- 4) Annual Fees – Average cost of fees that are charged per year
- 5) Graduation Fees – Average cost of graduation fees

77) The Price Template instruction sheet says “the PI to place a value in the 5 columns for the programs”. Does that mean we leave the Course Seats column blank.

ANSWER: The course seats column should not be adjusted.

78) For Current programs, does that mean new PIs can submit for those programs since they have already been awarded?

ANSWER: Yes. New PIs may price any of the programs (Current, planned, or [Insert]). Current means they are programs that are currently implemented under the current contract which is being succeeded with this opportunity.

79) Under Program, do I need to differentiate between an associate degree and a certificate?

ANSWER: Yes. You can annotate whether it is a certificate or degree in the program column

80) The Pricing Template has a Partner Institution column with filled in with letters A through O, do I replace one with my institution name and list all the programs in the single block under programs...so 10 program lines, a Program Management line and as IT/Data Support line?

ANSWER: Offerors may fill in the name of the institution. Offeror's should fill in the pricing data as described in question #1.

81) If YES to #5, do I delete the rest of the rows on the CLIN tab, leaving just the rows with my programs?

ANSWER: Do not delete extra rows.

82) Do you have any sense of the type of metrics require to track and report to the USNCC, and if so, are you able to share? We assume the regular student enrollment data, but would like to know if there are unique requirements of this consortium?

ANSWER: There are no unique requirements set forth by the USNCC. Institutions will report Census data and Financial data on a term-by-term basis. Other reporting requirements can be found in paragraphs 4.0 and 5.0 in the Performance Work Statement.

83) Will we have access to the data dictionary - or is there access somewhere you can reference to confirm whether or not we can map the data points per USNCC requirements?

ANSWER: Yes, the data dictionary is publicly accessible. You can use the link below to review the data points:

<https://usncc.atlassian.net/wiki/spaces/UDH/pages/421822466/Version+9.0+Data+Dictionary>

84) Regarding Data sharing and Confidentiality, APUS operates under the "Least amount of privilege/access to information in order to do their jobs" among staff/faculty. In item 8.3a Data Sharing and Confidentiality of the Secure Data Sharing Technical Requirements, it states, "The Partner Institution shall restrict data access to authorized personnel" Does APUS stance on this information align with the intent of this requirement - or can you provide more detail?

ANSWER: Yes, APUS's model aligns with our requirement.

85) As we are filling out the Pricing sheet, we do have some Undergrad Certs and Nano Certs. Should we add those in the appropriate [Insert Program] spaces provided, or only stick with our Associate Program level offerings?

ANSWER: Reference the answer to question #49. USNCC is open to learning more about any relevant industry certifications or micro-credentialing opportunities that may be associated with the academic program, as this information may provide helpful context.